

CATHY FREEMAN

As she entered the Olympic stadium midway through the opening ceremony of Sydney 2000, the message was loud and clear. Cathy Freeman, an Aboriginal, was given pride of place in Australia's biggest sporting moment in the new millennium. Born in 1973, Freeman was more of a 100m runner at the junior level and only transitioned to the one-lap race as a senior. After failing to make an impression at Barcelona 1992 at the age of 19, she scribbled "48.60, Atlanta" on the back of an airsickness bag on the return flight home. Four years later, she did just that, clocking 48.63s as she took silver behind Frenchwoman Marie-Jose Perec after being engaged in a neck-to-neck battle until the very last. On her victory lap, Freeman carried both the Australian flag and the Aboriginal national pendent, which was strictly against Olympic rules. But even the often-stern International Olympic Committee seemed pleased to look the other way, in quiet admiration of the valiant effort of this young Australian. Four years later in Sydney, Freeman became her country's second athlete to win the 400m gold, which turned out to be Australia's all-time 100th at the Summer Games.

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